

Enquiry Capture & Response

End-to-end n8n website-to-operations pipeline for commercial leads — technical & process documentation

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n8n

Google Sheets

Gmail

This report documents an n8n automation that turns a website enquiry form into a fully tracked, regionally-routed sales lead (built for the fictional BrightNest Commercial Cleaning as a portfolio example). It accepts submissions from any common WordPress form plugin, filters out spam, assigns the right regional owner, scores the lead's priority, logs it to Google Sheets before any email is attempted, and sends a branded acknowledgement to the customer plus a full hand-off to the owner.

1. Executive Summary

Website enquiry forms are a mess in practice: five different plugins name their fields five different ways, spam bots fill in honeypot fields, and leads land in an inbox with no consistent record of who owns them or how urgent they are. This workflow solves all three problems in one pass — it recognises fields by shape as well as name, rejects anything that looks like spam or is missing essentials, and guarantees the lead is safely logged to a spreadsheet before any email is even attempted, so a failed send can never lose a lead.

Metric	Detail
Trigger	A single webhook accepting POST submissions from any WordPress form plugin
Form compatibility	Contact Form 7, WPForms, Gravity Forms, Elementor, Fluent Forms, and unrecognised forms
Spam filtering	Honeypot field check, email format validation, and an "effectively empty form" check
Routing	Regional owner assigned by matching the longest postcode prefix, with a safe fallback
Priority scoring	Rule-based Low / Normal / High / Urgent score from company, phone, detail and urgency signals
Data safety	The lead is written to Google Sheets before any email is attempted, every time
Send safety	Three modes — preview (log only), test (redirect every email to one inbox), live

2. Business Value

- Works with whatever form plugin is already on the site — no need to standardise on one form builder or rebuild existing pages.
- Spam and junk filtered automatically — honeypot fields, invalid emails and empty submissions are rejected before they ever reach a human or the tracker.
- No lead ever silently lost — the sheet is written before any email is attempted, so a Gmail hiccup can never mean a lead vanishes.
- Urgent enquiries stand out — a transparent, rule-based priority score (with reasons attached) surfaces detailed or time-sensitive leads without needing an AI call.
- Safe to test before going live — preview and test modes let the whole pipeline, including real-looking emails, be verified without risking a live customer inbox.

3. Architecture Overview

The workflow is one continuous pipeline from webhook to website response, built around a central configuration node so every downstream step reads its settings from one place.

Stage	Purpose
Configure	Loads sheet ID, column mapping, regional routing rules, company details and the send-safety mode into one config object
Capture & standardise	Maps different form plugins' field names into one clean enquiry object, and detects spam/incomplete submissions
Route & score	Assigns a regional owner by postcode and calculates a Low–Urgent priority score
Compose & log	Builds the customer and owner email content, then writes the enquiry to Google Sheets before sending anything
Safety gate & send	Preview, test or live mode decides whether emails actually go out, and to whom
Website response	Returns a stable accepted / preview / rejected JSON result to the site, regardless of which branch ran

4. Step-by-Step Process

1

Capture the submission

A webhook accepts the website's POST request on a dedicated path, and a central configuration node loads the sheet ID, column headings, regional routing rules, company branding and send-safety mode used by every later step.

2

Standardise the form fields

Rather than hard-coding one plugin's field names, the workflow recognises common patterns across Contact Form 7, WPForms, Gravity Forms, Elementor and Fluent Forms — and where fields are sent as generic numbered inputs, it falls back to identifying values by shape (an email-looking string, a phone-looking string, a UK postcode pattern) so an unrecognised form still gets through cleanly.

3

Filter spam & incomplete submissions

A filled honeypot field, an invalid email address, or a submission with nothing usable in it is rejected before it reaches the tracker — with the exact rejection reason kept visible in the execution output for debugging, not silently discarded.

4

Assign the regional owner

The enquiry's postcode is matched against configured regional prefixes, longest prefix first (so a rule for "SW1" wins over a broader "SW" rule), and any enquiry that doesn't match a defined region still lands with a safe fallback owner — never nowhere.

5

Score the priority

A transparent, rule-based score adds points for a supplied company, phone number, a detailed message, urgent language ("asap", "this week", "emergency") and commercial-scope keywords (office, warehouse, school, etc.), and subtracts for a missing postcode — producing a Low, Normal, High or Urgent label with the reasons attached.

6

Compose both emails

A branded HTML (and plain-text) acknowledgement is built for the customer, naming their assigned owner and reference number and asking the three standard qualifying questions needed for a quote; a separate internal email is built for the owner with every captured detail and the customer's original message.

7

Log to the tracker first

The enquiry is written to the Google Sheets tracker as a single standardised row before any email is attempted, so the sheet remains the source of truth even if a later email step fails.

8

Apply the safety gate

Preview mode logs the lead and sends nothing at all; test mode redirects every email (both customer and owner copies) to one configured test inbox; live mode sends to the real customer and owner addresses — controlled by a single configuration flag so it's impossible to accidentally live-send during testing.

9

Send the emails (when enabled)

The customer receives their acknowledgement first; the workflow then checks whether the assigned owner actually has an email configured before attempting the internal notification — if not, the lead is still safely logged and the workflow completes without failing.

10

Return a stable response to the website

Regardless of which branch ran, a dedicated step converts the outcome into one predictable JSON shape — accepted, preview, or rejected — with the human-readable reference number, so the site can show a useful message without exposing any internal workflow details.

5. Node-by-Node Map

Stage	Key nodes
Capture & configure	When Cleaning Enquiry Arrives → Configure Enquiry Pipeline → Parse Form Fields
Spam gate	Check If Real Enquiry → Handle Spam or Incomplete (rejected branch)
Route & score	Assign Enquiry Owner → Score Enquiry Priority
Compose & log	Compose First Reply → Prepare Sheet Row → Append Enquiry to Sheets
Safety gate	Check Sending Condition → Preview Mode: No Email Sent (if disabled)
Send	Send Reply to Customer → Verify Owner Email Exists → Notify Owner via Email / No Owner Email Defined
Website response	Build Website Response → Send Webhook Response to Site

6. Reliability & Security Design

- **Sheet written before any email** — the enquiry is logged to Google Sheets first, so a Gmail failure can never mean a lead is lost, only that a notification is delayed.
- **Three-mode send safety** — preview, test and live are controlled by one configuration flag, making it structurally difficult to accidentally send real emails while testing.
- **Graceful missing-owner handling** — if a matched region has no configured owner email, the workflow still completes and logs the lead rather than failing the whole run.
- **Transparent spam & scoring logic** — both the rejection reason and the priority score's contributing factors are kept on the item, so every decision is auditable from the execution output.
- **Resilient email sends** — both the customer and owner email nodes are configured to continue the workflow even if the email step itself fails, so one delivery problem never blocks logging or the website response.

7. Setup Checklist

- Add your Google Sheet ID in Configure Enquiry Pipeline and confirm the Enquiries tab's header row matches the column configuration exactly.
- Replace the sample regional owners, postcode prefixes, company name, phone, website and reply-to address in the configuration node.
- Connect Google Sheets and Gmail credentials on the Append Enquiry to Sheets, Send Reply to Customer and Notify Owner via Email nodes.
- Keep TEST_RUN = true and set a real TEST_EMAIL address for your first tests, so every email is safely redirected to one inbox.
- Submit three test cases: one fully valid enquiry, one with a missing/invalid email, and one with the honeypot field filled in, then check the sheet and (in test mode) your inbox.
- Once verified, set TEST_RUN = false and switch the form on the live site to point at the webhook's Production URL.

This workflow was designed and built end-to-end in n8n as part of an AI automation portfolio, demonstrating multi-plugin form parsing, rule-based lead scoring, region-based routing and a log-before-send data safety pattern.